

How the Death-themed Game *Spiritfarer* Can Help Players Cope with the Loss of a Loved One

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ABSTRACT

While commercial videogames are increasingly recognized to be able to facilitate meaningful experiences, little has been researched on its potential as a medium to help players cope with the loss of a loved one. In this study, we aimed to investigate the player's bereavement process while playing the commercial death-themed game *Spiritfarer*. Through a thematic analysis of qualitative in-depth interviews with 6 participants, we found that the player's grieving experience closely resembled the Dual Process Model of Coping with Bereavement by Stroebe and Schut. In the game, players oscillated between facing loss-orientation stressors ('Character resemblance to the deceased', 'Sending characters away') and restoration-orientation stressors ('Taking care of remaining spirits'). Through this process, the participants coped with and sometimes reappraised their loss. We further found that the players' bereavement experience and level of engagement greatly varied depending on their 'prior loss experience', 'gaming environment' and 'tendency to focus on self or game'. Those differences were partly accommodated by the game through its complex and diverse characters and engaging game elements. We conclude with insights for future works in game design for bereavement support.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Human-centered computing → User studies; • Applied computing → Computer games.

KEYWORDS

Player experience; Bereavement and games; Videogame on death and loss

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1 INTRODUCTION

Games are slowly being established as a complex medium able to facilitate various engaging experiences. There have been increasing applications of games in fields of education, health as well as psychotherapy [13][6]. Games can recreate situations which can provide a rich environment for the player to project their thoughts, feelings and connect their real-life experiences.

Losing people to death can result in immense grief and can present great challenges in one's life. Games can provide an environment for bereavement by providing a space for both reflection on the loss and an enjoyable playing experience. However, there is limited research on games as a medium to facilitate the bereavement process, despite its widening recognition as a complex medium able to encourage reflection and emotional engagement. Research on games and bereavement has been largely focused on treating games as a tool for storytelling [10][20], but studies that investigate how the bereaved players cope with their real-life loss through games, particularly through commercial games, are still scarce. To fill in this gap, we investigated how players can experience coping with their loss experience in game medium focusing on the case of players who played a death-themed game, *Spiritfarer*.

2 LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Bereavement models

When people confront loss, they go through a bereavement process, a process of responding and adapting to grief they experience due to the loss. Freud first suggested that coping with bereavement requires 'grief work', or breaking a psychological bond between the deceased and the bereaved. Later theorists developed this concept into stage theories, suggesting that bereavement occurs in a sequence of stages [14] [4] [9], a notable example being the five stages of grief model by Kübler-Ross [14]. Worden further extended the idea to the task model that lists four tasks of grief that the bereaved should accomplish for successful coping [29]. Stage models,

however, has been criticized for failing to encompass the complexity and diversity of grief and the bereavement process across bereaved individuals [9]. This led to the emergence of new bereavement theories which highlight individual variation in bereavement. Here we focus on the Dual Process Model of Coping with Bereavement, which we used as a conceptual framework analyzing our results.

2.1.1 The Dual Process Model of Coping with Bereavement. The Dual Process Model of Coping with Bereavement (DPM) by Stroebe and Schut describes the bereavement process as a set of coping mechanism with the loss of loved ones. It borrows a parameter ‘stressor’ from Cognitive Stress Theory, which defines stressors as real-life situations that are appraised to be too stressful [16][23]. In DPM, two unique types of stressors are introduced: loss-orientation stressors and restoration-orientation stressors. Facing loss-orientation stressors involves processing the loss experience itself, such as reminiscing the time spent together with the deceased or longing for the deceased. Meanwhile, facing restoration-orientation stressors involve dealing with the consequences of the loss, an effort to reorient oneself in a world without the deceased. These involve handling practical issues ranging from tackling financial problems to new identity development. The bereaved has to cope with these two stressors in their everyday life, confronting or avoiding stressors when they face them, and constructing new meanings for them in a positive or negative way. This dynamic coping process of moving back and forth between loss- and restoration-orientation stressors is named oscillation [23]. The extended DPM deems the oscillation between positive and negative reappraisal and affect a necessary process for a successful adaption to the loss [24]. The model also addresses that oscillation can occur in various degrees according to individual and cultural contexts [22][24].

2.2 Bereavement and games

There has been considerable research looking into how technology can encourage reflection about mortality and death [12] as well as support grieving [1, 8]. However, the game medium has not been subject to much attention in that field. Furthermore, compared to the omnipresence of death in video games [10], bereavement has received surprisingly little attention in game research. Only few games deliberately focus on the topic of death and bereavement (For example, *Spiritfarer* [27], *Apart of me* [3], *Existence* [5], *That Dragon, Cancer* [18], *A Mortician’s Tale* [15], *The Graveyard* [25]). The existing research on such games has mainly focused on how games can be an expressive outlet of the grieving game designer [10] or how games can encourage reflection on existential questions [5]. However there is few studies on how players can cope with loss through games. McGuire [17] investigates how playing the game *Mandagon* [2] is structurally similar to experiencing grief, however the author does not study how the game can support the player in their grieving process. Recently, two games were developed intending to support grieving players. *Apart of me* is a mobile game for young people suffering from the loss of a close one. In this game, the player explores an island, hears stories of other young bereft people and learns mindfulness and meditation techniques [3]. *Spiritfarer* is a management game which lets the player interact with and take care of diverse spirit characters, which then need to be sent away to the afterworld [27]. Those games

have not yet been subject to research, particularly focusing on the player’s grief experience during the game play. We therefore chose to investigate the player’s bereavement experience while playing *Spiritfarer*, choosing this game due to its higher complexity and appeal to a broader audience.

3 METHOD

3.1 Game choice

To investigate how the player reflects on loss-experiences in a death-themed game, we decided to study the player’s experience of the game *Spiritfarer* [27]. *Spiritfarer* is a management game, where the player-character ‘Stella’ should manage a ship which carries lost spirits of the deceased and accompany them until they are ready to pass on to the after-world, by sending them through a place called ‘Everdoor’. While taking care of the spirits, the player learns about each spirit’s story. The game is a commercial game available on Steam in several languages for PC as well as various consoles [7]. The game is one of the very few games directly addressing the topic of loss and was very well received on Steam reviews. Reviews reported that the game engaged many players to reflect on their own loss experience and helped coping with grief. We therefore chose this game for our study.

3.2 Participants

We recruited participants via Steam based on their reviews about *Spiritfarer*. We contacted participants based on two criteria: their accounts of their game experience and its connection to their real-life loss experience mentioned in the review, and having sent at least one spirit away. In total, we recruited 6 participants (5 male and 1 female, mean age=26.17 years); each two English-, Chinese-, and Korean-speakers, with a varying gameplay time. All participants were compensated with a 30-dollar Steam gift card. Also, the recruitment process and ethical considerations have been approved by the institutional review board of the authors’ institute. **Table 1** provides the basic information of participants we recruited.

3.3 Data collection and analysis

Our study was designed in three stages. First, data was collected via 1 hour long semi-structured interviews. Due to the COVID-19 pandemic, all interviews were conducted via Zoom in participant’s native language. The collected data was transcribed and translated into English. In reference to Weiss’ work [28], we asked participants their gameplay context, impressive game moments and reasons why in relation to their life, and changes in perception on their real-life loss experience.

In order to reduce the risk of emotionally upsetting the participants, we recruited players who already shared their game experiences online and handed them our interview questions in advance. We further structured the questions starting from less emotionally engaging topics to questions about their real-life loss experience in relation to game moments. We also notified them that they can stop or ask to leave the interview at any time if they felt uncomfortable. To prepare for the potentially emotionally engaging interviews, we researchers played the game in advance, reflected on our own game experiences and related real-life losses and discussed them,

Table 1: Study Participants

Participants	Nationality	Gender	Age	Playing hours
P1	Chinese	M	19	18
P2	British	M	19	34
P3	American	F	21	47
P4	Korean	M	32	27.5
P5	Korean	M	32	25
P6	Chinese	M	34	18

so that we were able to understand our subjective standpoint as researchers and manage our own emotional reactions.

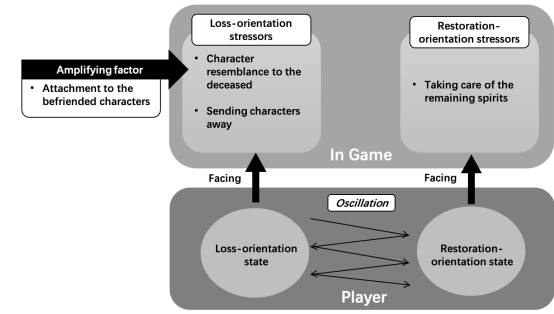
In the second step, the interviews were transcribed and translated to English. Lastly, we conducted a thematic analysis in reference to Gareth, Hayfield, Braun and Clarke’s work [26]. We combined a bottom-up coding approach with a top-down theme formation based on existing theoretical models of bereavement. This approach enabled us to explore the unknown territory of the grieving experience in games and to provide meaningful insights in relation to existing bereavement theory. First, transcripts were inductively coded in a bottom-up approach, then codes were grouped into 21 themes using affinity diagramming. Thematic maps were then developed using those themes, which were placed and connected in relation to either the grieving process in the game or player differences in bereavement. The final 3 themes concerning the bereavement process were then formed in a top-down approach based on existing theoretical bereavement models, from which we found the DPM to best fit our data. The 3 themes concerning the player differences were finalized in a bottom-up fashion through repeated discussion and consultation of the original transcripts.

4 RESULTS

4.1 Bereavement experience in *Spiritfarer* in relation to the dual process model

Concerning how players experienced the bereavement process within the game, three themes emerged: character resemblance to the deceased, sending characters away, and taking care of the remaining spirits. In regards to these three themes, we were able to find a recurring pattern of bereavement within the game which was similar to the DPM, which we described in figure 1. Note that we used the term ‘state’ here; although the original model does not use such term and describes oscillation as moving back and forth between two types of stressors, we found that separately naming players’ experience would be important to prevent confusion. Therefore we named the experience when facing loss-orientation stressor “loss orientation state”, and “restoration orientation state” respectively, and oscillation as moving back and forth between two player states. As illustrated in figure 1, players encountered several in-game moments which can be understood as loss- and restoration-orientation stressors, which let them enter loss- or restoration-orientation states. Repeated moving back and forth between two states created the oscillation between two player states which closely resembled the oscillation described in the DPM, and it encouraged them to revisit or even reappraise their loss experience, facilitating a coping process. We elaborate on the process below.

4.1.1 Loss-orientation stressors. Players reported two types of main moments that they identified as loss-orientation stressors:

**Figure 1: Dual process of bereavement observed in bereaved *Spiritfarer* players**

when they found characters’ resemblance to ones they lost, and when they sent characters away.

- (1) **Character resemblance to the deceased:** In the game, players often encountered spirit characters that resembled their lost ones in personality, behavior or the cause of death. Discovering the character’s resemblance to the deceased led to reminiscing about their memories with them. For instance, P2 connected the spirit character with his grandmother because they both suffered from the symptoms of dementia.
- (2) **Sending characters away:** Furthermore, sending away spirits in the game, whether by exchanging a farewell hug at the Everdoor or not, reminded them of how they parted with the deceased in real life. For example, P3 mentioned how a character’s sudden disappearance reminded her of the sudden loss of her teacher and the painful memories of not being able to say goodbye.

Encountering above loss-orientation stressors sometimes led to a reappraisal of the loss. For instance, P2 reported that sending away a character who reminded him of his deceased grandmother actually made him view her passing in a positive way.

P2: “When you have to let Alice go, that kind of hammered home how much kind of good thing it was that [my grandma] sort of could rest (...) it made me kind of appreciate it more (...).”

It is noteworthy that attachment with the characters strengthened the overall process of grief work; the complexity and diversity of character design as well as interactions players can exchange with them all contributed to attachment-building which amplified the positive or negative affect participants felt in response to the stressors.

4.1.2 Restoration-orientation stressors. Resolving tasks such as ‘Taking care of remaining spirits’ which were not directly related to sending spirits away or being reminded of the deceased, were understood as restoration-oriented stressors.

- (1) **Taking care of the remaining spirits:** As a management game *Spiritfarer* requires players to manage the spirit passengers’ mood throughout the journey. To keep other spirits’ mood high, players had to cook their meal, farm, mine and keep the ship in good shape. Performing daily ‘chores’ was

considered a realistic portrayal of life after loss to players like P4:

P4: “I thought the game system [taking care of spirits] was realistic in a sense that even if I lose someone, I have to come back to normal life. Those who are left have to continue their life.”

Similarly, P3 was reminded of the need to “move on”:

P3: “The game helped me remember that [people you care about] may be gone, but their memories are still there and you still have all these other people in your life that you need to care about (...) you need to continue to move forward without being stuck on some loss.(...)the game help to remind me that no matter who you lose, there’s going to be other people that can help you through it.”

4.1.3 Oscillation. While exploring the relationship between the themes, we discovered that players moved between the loss- and restoration-orientation states, which closely resembled the oscillation described in the DPM. As the game progressed, players repeatedly befriended and sent away multiple spirits followed by meeting new spirits. Through this process players oscillated between two states, which often led to new viewpoints about the deceased, changed perceptions on the loss experience, and in some cases, extended to thoughts about people who would have to cope with the participants own death. In case of P5, playing the game led to different interpretation of his loss and expanded to thoughts about people around him after his own death.

P5: “I thought if there is a world after death, [my grandmother] would have regretted that [she didn’t leave a message]. In the game I sent away other characters besides Summer, and they told me some stories they had in their minds. So I thought(...)by telling me their stories they got the determination to leave(...) I thought I should leave a note or something I wanted to tell people around me before I leave, so that they can know even if I die by accident. So, I wrote them down.”

It is noteworthy that this oscillation naturally took place through the design mechanisms of *Spiritfarer*. The game was designed so that the player must talk to spirits in order to progress, which leads them to learn more about spirits, build an emotional attachment to them and send them away. This was a deliberate choice of game designers to encourage players to interact as “part of a story”[19]. This design scheme, combined with game medium’s unique interactivity, enabled players to actively participate in this oscillation.

4.2 Accommodating individual differences in bereavement

In our study we could find that our participants were grieving in different ways and to a varying degree. While our participants’ grieving behaviour in the game generally followed the previously described pattern of oscillation, their game experience and level of engagement in the grieving process varied. We describe this diversity of players by the 3 main themes ‘Prior experience’, ‘Gaming environment’ and ‘Focus on self or game’. We further present how

we think the game *Spiritfarer* managed to address each theme and keep a diversity of players engaged through its game elements. This will provide insights into how a game can be designed to encourage grieving processes for a diverse player base.

4.2.1 Prior loss experience. : All players had their own unique real-life loss experiences; their relationship with the lost one, the level of attachment and recency of the loss were all different. Therefore the ways in which the players related their real-life and game experience also varied. For example P3 related both the character Atul’s personality traits as well as his sudden disappearance to her lost teacher:

P3: “Atul was very, you know, again happy, happy-go-lucky super-friendly. My teacher was also that, but he was also, they were both crafty, they work with their hands, they build sets (...)”

In P5’s case, rather than the character’s personality traits, he related the character Summer’s life-story of long suffering from an illness with his grandmother’s physical struggles before passing away:

P5: “The character Summer is actually a character with a backstory, so the dragon that followed her was a symbol of cancer. (...) It reminded me of my grandmother a lot. She also tried to deal with physical problems, but no matter how she tried to mentally overcome them, there was a limit, so she left.”

Corresponding game elements: The game addressed those differences in experiences of the player by creating complex and diverse characters. Complex characters enable resemblance in a variety of ways, based on character’s personality (P3), in-game behavior(P2,3) or background story(P5). Secondly, diverse characters can represent a large pool of possible reference points based on which a player might find resemblance to their real-life lost person.

4.2.2 Gaming environment. : The environment in which participants played the game seemed to affect their bereaving experience as well. Two sub-themes were identified: ‘Having an audience’ (P3,4), such as streaming the game online, affected how the game is perceived and played by the player. This could then affect the engagement in the bereavement process, as some players claimed to engage more deeply with the game and the topic of death through having an audience. For instance P4 mentioned how he got to think about how a viewers reaction made him think about the game and the topic of death again:

P4: “There was a viewer (...) he must have experienced a lot of separation and death when he was young. So he watched all my videos and later thanked me for playing it. That was an opportunity for me to think about it again. That was amazing. There’s something more to this game, I’m sure.”

‘Sharing experiences during and after gameplay’ (P2,3,6) refers to sharing one’s gaming experience with other people outside the game, such as friends or partners. This could also increase the engagement in the bereavement process, as, for example, resemblances of characters to deceased were shared and thereby revisited, as explained by P2:

P2: “I could kind of talk to her [girlfriend] about what’s going on and I mention to her like this moment [with Alice character] was like really similar, really reminded me of my grandma.”

Corresponding game elements: While there is a multi-player functionality in the game and the game can be streamed online, there is no functionality of the game specifically targeted to encourage social interactions or sharing of experiences during or after gameplay.

4.2.3 Focus on self or game. : During the gameplay, some players actively related many of their game experiences with their own life and losses, while others almost exclusively focused on game elements, and took on a more game-design focused lens of the game. Based on this tendency, the level of engagement in the bereavement process varied greatly. Participants whose reactions tended to focus on themselves (one’s feelings, thoughts and related experiences) showed a high tendency to more actively confront loss and restoration-orientation stressors within the game. For example, P3 actively connected many in-game events with her real life and often talked about the game in connection to herself.

P3: “I think I want to talk about Alice for a second, the hedgehog. I saw a lot of her in my grandmother. she’s still alive right now, thankfully. But her passion of like clothing and like little things and stories like my grandma, she loves to tell stories, she loves to build little sets and it really reminded me of my grandma and how much I care about her (...).”

Those who focused more on game elements (characters, visuals, mechanics) were more reluctant to connect in-game elements to their real life and loss-experiences, mentioning that ‘the game is just a game’. For instance, P4 mentioned that “the death I accept is the death in reality, and the game is not reality, it’s just a game.” This is in line with [24], which states that individuals attend to loss and restoration orientation stressors to a varying degree.

Corresponding game elements: As described in the previous section, the game encourages the player to engage in a bereavement process, however the game can not change the player’s personal tendency to focus on oneself or the game. It does provide an enjoyable experience for all players though, also those focusing more on the game, through engaging elements related to the themes of ‘Enjoyable atmosphere’ and ‘Exploration’, whose detailed description is omitted due to the focus on the bereavement process in this study.

5 DISCUSSION

Unique bereavement experiences in the game

Our study revealed unique bereavement experiences players had while playing *Spiritfarer*. In the game, participants were able to experience a coping process similar to the Dual Process Model [21][22]; they alternately confronted stressors related to their real-life loss, an oscillation which led to reappraising the deceased and their own perceptions on the loss. However, our findings expand the model because it reflects the role of the game’s interactive nature on players’ bereavement process. The original model describes stressors as real-life events that lead to stress.

In our finding, the stressors players encountered were in-game moments which were perceived to be stressful only after they projected their real-life loss experiences on them. This projection as well as oscillation occurred while players actively interacted with game elements. The interactive nature of the game medium let players experience *Spiritfarer* as a “designed experience”[21] where players were able to actively cope with grief. The complex emotions participants reported goes in line with [11] which views game as a distinct medium that can evoke social emotion from a fictional experience. Through the incorporation of the game medium’s interactivity *Spiritfarer* successfully designed a world where players can actively cope with personal loss in a way not available in other mediums.

Limitation and future work

Our study has some limitations worth noting. Since all interviews were first conducted in the participants’ native language and then translated, information that contain detailed nuance specific to cultural context may have been left out in the translation process. We also acknowledge that skewed gender distribution of participants may also have affected the result. However, we also found major opportunities for further investigations in the process. For instance, we found slight differences in perception of game, self and loss across individuals while interviewing culturally diverse participants. Due to limited time we did not explore whether such difference in perception was significantly correlated to cultural background, but investigating how much impact cultural background can have on players’ bereavement experiences in game medium can provide attractive research questions.

Also, we would like to note design insights we gained which worth further research. One such insight is that bereaved gamers are not homogenous; our study found that their differences in regards to prior loss experience, gaming environment, and game focus all led to different game experiences. We also saw the game’s potential to accommodate such differences across players by designing complex and diverse characters, enjoyable atmosphere and exploratory game mechanics. Future works with bigger samples can develop these insights into design frameworks that game designers can refer to when designing games that can help bereaved players to cope with their loss and provide them with a richer game experience.

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